

“ I CAN DO BUSINESS WITH ZARDARI ”

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elected as the country's new president, for example. But colourful stories about Zardari's extravagances soon began doing the rounds. He was accused of using public municipal resources to build a private polo ground in the PM House and of rearing his ponies in specially constructed air-conditioned stables. By the time the PPP government was dismissed once again in 1996—this time by Leghari—the charges were considerably more serious. They included allegations of multi-million dollar kickbacks in defence deals and other international con-



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tracts, of amassing assets beyond known sources of income, as well as at least three murder charges, including that of Bhutto's brother Murtaza, Sindh High Court judge Nizam Ahmed and former Federal secretary Alam Baloch. Zardari found himself in jail once again, this time for eight long years, although the cases never reached conclusion. He was elected PPP senator while still in jail and remained so until parliament was dissolved after General Musharraf's coup in 1999.

Under Musharraf's Government,

the newly set up National Accountability Commission followed up on the Bhutto-Zardari international assets with a vengeance, prompting cases in Switzerland, Spain and the UK. The couple was accused of having off-shore accounts, buying undeclared luxurious property and jewellery and siphoning off up to \$1.5 billion through corrupt practices. Convicted in Geneva of profiting from corruption—in a famous case where two Swiss companies, SGS and Cotecna, were granted a Pakistan government contract for pre-shipment customs inspections of all imports—both husband and wife were sentenced to six months in prison and forfeiture of their assets, but the conviction was suspended on appeal as per Swiss law.

Meanwhile, having denied for years in court the ownership of the luxurious 365-acre Rockwood Estate known in Pakistan as the Surrey Palace, Zardari finally admitted owning the property in 2004. PPP insiders claim that Bhutto was genuinely unaware of his connection with the property and that this breach of trust caused a rift in their marriage at the time. Another case of money laundering in which Zardari is the main accused is still pending a decision in Geneva, and from the looks of it, the Pakistan Government is in no hurry to have the case quashed, despite Musharraf's promulgation of the National Reconciliation Ordinance, which absolves Zardari of corruption cases within Pakistan.

Rumours of marital discord—after Zardari was freed on bail in 2004 he moved to the US ostensibly for medical treatment while Bhutto continued living with their children in London and Dubai—were never confirmed and recently publicly denied. But today, he is a much-changed man. Gone is the trademark flamboyance and the obvious swagger, replaced by a seriousness and maturity that befits the new co-chairman of the largest political party in Pakistan. Those who met him during his incarceration say the change came about during his second term in jail.

Some of it may have to do with age or with the ailments he suffers from—he is said to have developed diabetes and spondylitis—but he also seems to be taking his political career seriously.

Although never much of a reader or inclined towards intellectualism, during court appearances he would seize the opportunity to discuss politics and strategies with the journalists present. When INDIA TODAY asked him about his years in jail, Zardari turned philosophical, saying, "It has taught me to live with myself, to look into myself and make my inner self as big as any problem is and confront it." He chokes with emotion when he recalls his special relationship with Bhutto and says, "We respected each other, we respected each other's space, we were an extension of each other." As an example of their closeness, he says that on her last drive to Liaquat Bagh, where she was martyred, Bhutto told Naheed, her personal secretary, "Asif won't like the fact that I am wearing a silk dress today." Zardari had asked her to wear cotton because silk catches fire very quickly. She had written glowingly about her marital life: "I found joy and fulfilment in marriage despite difficult circumstances. I am proud of my husband for his courage and loyalty."

Zardari, in turn, says he was inspired by her "commitment and bravery" and vows to take her legacy forward. He says that if Bhutto had not willed that he take over as chairman of the party, he would have probably ended up running charitable institutions she had started. "By binding me to her legacy, she has shown the path for the future," he explains. Some close friends of the family are already expressing doubt that he can resist the pull of real political power. They point to the fact that Bhutto's traditional seat in Larkana will still be up for contesting in the by-elections after February 18. Others say that Musharraf's Government would cut short any such ambition by threatening to re-open cases of corruption against him. It is apparent to everyone though that Asif Ali Zardari has truly arrived. ■